

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

Below is an extract from a magazine article about apprenticeships:

Apprenticeship programmes in Switzerland

An apprenticeship is a formal, on-the-job training programme through which a trainee learns a marketable craft or trade under the guidance of a master craftsman or tradesman.

In Switzerland, apprenticeships are a critical part of the secondary education system, and most students complete an apprenticeship even if they plan to pursue post-secondary education in the future. Almost 70% of students between the ages of 16 and 19 participate in a dual-enrollment track which allows them to study one to two days per week in a vocational education and training (VET) programme and spend the rest of their time in a paid-on-the-job training programme that lasts three to four years.

One of the main benefits of the Swiss apprenticeship system is that students of all socio-economic and ability levels are engaged in this form of learning. The popularity of the apprenticeship system is proof that these programmes are not just for people who can't get into university.

Moreover, because students entering dual-track VET programmes are often high performers, they are no less academic than students who chose university education rather than vocational training or dual education. As a result, Swiss dual-track VET students are likely to enter the workplace well prepared for work and having strong academic skills.

Your group is looking into the possibility of introducing apprenticeship programmes to school students. You may want to talk about:

- the differences between apprenticeships and traditional schooling
- whether Hong Kong students and parents would be open to the idea of apprenticeship programmes
- how to get support from employers to take part in apprenticeship programmes
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Do you like studying practical subjects?
2. Are you good at making things?
3. Do you think an apprenticeship would be boring?
4. Would you prefer on-the-job training to learning in a classroom environment?
5. Do you think that Hong Kong schools should offer more job training for their students?
6. If you were an employer, what qualities would you look for in a trainee?
7. Do you think schools adequately prepare their students for the workplace?
8. Do you think Hong Kong's educational system meets the needs of society?